

AI Energy Consumption: Statistics from Key Sources [2026]

Posted by u/EchoOfOppenheimer • 0 points • 5 comments

A new comprehensive analysis of AI energy use reveals staggering numbers for 2026. While generating text is relatively efficient, generating just **1,000 AI images** produces carbon emissions equivalent to driving a gas car for **4.1 miles**. The report also warns that by 2028, AI-specific servers in the US alone could consume up to **326 TWh** of electricity annually, roughly 12% of the country's entire forecast power demand. The invisible cost of inference is now growing faster than training, meaning every day use is adding up to a massive environmental bill.

Comments

u/Little-Dealer4903 • 3 points • 2026-01-15 13:54 UTC

How can you stop AI when searches? Especially in google and even dukduck go have AI answers .

u/Geoggler • 1 points • 2026-03-08 19:45 UTC

Look in settings and preferences, there's often a way to turn it off.

u/MudnuK • 2 points • 2026-01-15 12:49 UTC

For reference, [Ember, via Wikipedia,]

(https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_countries_by_electricity_consumption) says 415 tWh per year would make AI the 12th most energy-hungry country in the world. How does this compare to other energy use cases, like video streaming or refrigeration or street lighting?

u/sg_plumber • 1 points • 2026-01-15 17:10 UTC

Far as anyone really knows, those are imaginary numbers.

u/sg_plumber • 2 points • 2026-01-15 12:06 UTC

Nothing really new, including their already-in-use recommendations.

The hype isn't justified by the stats in the article:

> **Electricity and total demand:**

> * US data centers: 4.4% of total US electricity goes to data centers.

> * AI within US data centers: AI-specific servers used an *estimated* 53-76 terawatt-hours (TWh) in

2024, and *projections suggest* 165-326 TWh by 2028.

> ****Global electricity consumption from data centers:****

> * Estimated ~415 TWh in 2024, about 1.5% of global electricity consumption.

> * *Projected to reach* ~945 TWh by 2030, just under 3% of global electricity consumption in the IEA base case.

u/Economy-Fee5830 • 5 points • 2026-01-15 10:14 UTC

> generating just 1,000 AI images produces carbon emissions equivalent to driving a gas car for 4.1 miles

I doubt the average AI user generates 1000 images - I would say 100 per year is probably reasonable, while the average American drives 12,000 miles per year.